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An Astrologer's Day

- R.K. Narayan

• Understanding the text

* Answer the following questions.

a) How does the Astrologer's appearance help him attract customers? How does he help the customers satisfy their needs?

Ans: The astrologer dresses in a way that makes him look holy and wise. He puts sacred ash and vermillion on his forehead and wears a saffron turban. This professional look impresses people and makes them trust him. To help ~~the~~ his customers, he listens carefully to their problems for several minutes. He then uses common sense and clever guesses to give them advice that makes them feel better about their lives and future.

b) How do you characterise the astrologer's attitude towards the stranger?

Ans: At first, the astrologer is professional and wants to make money, so he treats the stranger like any other customer. However, once he recognizes the stranger as a man from his past, he becomes very afraid and tries to back out of the deal. Finally, he becomes clever and bold. He uses his secret knowledge to trick the st-

ranger into believing he is a powerful soul-reader so the stranger will leave him alone forever.

c) What details does the astrologer give the stranger about his past?

Ans: The astrologer tells the stranger very specific things that only the stranger would know. He says that the stranger was stabbed with a knife years ago and left for dead in a well. He even reveals the stranger's name, Guru Nayak. By sharing these accurate details about the stranger being attacked and left in a field, the astrologer proves his 'Powers' and gains the stranger's complete trust without revealing his own identity.

d) Why does he advise the stranger to go home immediately?

Ans: The astrologer tells the stranger that his life is in great danger if he stays away from his village. He claims that the man who attacked the stranger is already dead, having been crushed by a truck in a far-off town. By giving this advice, the astrologer ensures that Guru Nayak will stop searching for his attacker and go back home, allowing the astrologer to live the rest of his life in peace.

Q. What is your reaction to the conversation between the astrologer and his wife?

Ans. The conversation shows the astrologer's hidden side. After a long day, he tells his wife that a 'great load' is gone because the man he thought he killed is actually alive. It is surprising to see that his 'holy man' was actually a criminal in his youth. The scene is full of relief. It shows that he is a simple man who can finally sleep peacefully now that his guilty conscience is clear.

• Reference to the content

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i) Who is the speaker?

Ans. The astrologer is the speaker.

ii) Who is he speaking to?

Ans. He is speaking to Guru Nayak.

iii) What does the expression 'open my mouth' mean?

Ans. The expression 'open my mouth' means to speak and give vital information.

Q.

a) Suspense is the feeling of anticipation you may have as you read. In this story, what details contributed to your feelings of suspense and surprise? Explain.

Ans. Suspense builds through the astrologer's mysterious behaviour and secretive personality. This sudden ~~and~~ nervousness when the ~~extra~~ stranger appears creates strong anticipation. The dim setting, late hours and tense ~~dialogue~~ dialogue heighten uncertainty, making the reader curious about the connection between two men and what hidden truth ~~between~~ might soon emerge.

The conversation itself deepens the suspense. The stranger's persistence, the astrologer's hesitation, and the gradual revelation of past events keep readers fully engaged. Each clue revealed slowly, maintaining tension. The fact that the main character who pretended to be an astrologer could get details of a random stranger makes the reader suspicious as to what connection the fake astrologer might have to a random person.

The final twist that the astrologer himself was the attacker creates surprise. This unexpected revelation resolves suspense while leaving a lasting emotional impact on reader.

b. Analyze the conflicts in "An astrologer's Day."
Explain how the conflicts are ~~reptate~~ resolved and what they reveal about the characters involved in the story.

Ans. The story presents both internal and external conflicts centered on the astrologer. Internally he struggles with guilt and fear from violent past, believing he once killed a man. Externally, the sudden encounter with the stranger creates tension, as his hidden identity risks being exposed, threatening his present life and safety.

The conflict reaches its peak during their intense, heated up conversation. Using cleverness, the astrologer narrates the stranger's past and convinces him that his attacker is dead. This resolves the external conflict by removing suspicion and danger.

The resolution reveals that astrologer's intelligence, adaptability and desire for redemption. His relief afterward shows lingering guilt, while his actions highlight survival instincts and moral complexity.

d) Description helps readers visualize what is happening in a story. What details and techniques does the author use to describe the astrologer?

Ans The author uses vivid physical details to make the astrologer visually striking. His saffron, turban, ash-marked forehead and flowing robes create a mystical appearance. These elements are carefully chosen to give him an air of wisdom and authority, helping readers easily imagine him as a traditional fortune teller.

Descriptive techniques like imagery and contrast enhance their portrayal. The bright colors of his outfit stand out against the dim marketplace, while his calm posture contrasts with the busy surroundings, drawing attention to him.

The description also reveals his character indirectly. His artificial appearance and practice gestures suggest that his identity is ~~constructed~~ constructed, highlighting his cleverness, adaptation and dependence on illusion for survival.

c) Irony is a contrast between appearances and reality. What is ironic about Guru Nayak's meeting with the astrologer?

Ans: The irony lies in the unexpected meeting between Guru Nayak and the astrologer who is actually the man that one tried to kill him (Guru Nayak). Guru Nayak approaches him seeking information about his attacker, unaware that he is speaking to the very person responsible. This sharp contrast, between appearance and reality creates strong dramatic ~~to~~ irony.

The astrologer, pretending to be a wise fortune teller, hides his true identity while guiding Guru Nayak away from revenge. The ~~actual~~ situation is tense because the truth remains concealed. It is also ironic as the astrologer used to be violent in his youth but now he is trying to ward off any possible violent outcomes.

This irony highlights fate and coincidence. It reveals the astrologer's cleverness and survival instinct while showing Guru Nayak's ~~ignor~~ ignorance. The encounter resolves their past without either fully realizing the deeper truth.

f) How does the astrologer's manner of dress suit his character?

Ans The astrologer's manner of dress perfectly suits his deceptive yet intelligent character. His saffron turban, ash markings, and flowing robes create an image of spirituality and wisdom. This outward appearance helps him gain trust easily, even though he lacks real astrological knowledge, making his profession depend on performance rather than genuine skill.

His clothing also reflects his cleverness and adaptability. By carefully constructing this identity, he hides his past and survives through observation and speech. The contrast between his false appearance and real personality reveals his practical mindset and ability to manipulate situations effectively.

Moreover, his dress acts as a protective disguise, allowing him to escape recognition. It symbolizes how he has rebuilt his life through illusions, showing that appearance can shape perception, control others, and ensure his continued survival in a challenging world.